

PUBLIC ART / 2024 / CHICAGO, IL

Flight of Butterflies

Peggy Notebaert Nature Museum



Twenty nine cast aluminum butterfly sculptures installed across Chicago, each finished by a local artist.

THE WORK

Twenty nine six-foot butterflies across Chicago, from Lakeview to South Shore to Austin, each finished by a different local artist, for the Peggy Notebaert Nature Museum. Two species, the Regal Fritillary and the Black Swallowtail, carried out of the museum and into neighborhoods across the city.

THE MATERIAL QUESTION

One blank, twenty nine artists, and a year outdoors in Chicago. The sculpture had to be a clean canvas any artist could work on, and survive whatever they put on it.

THE MAKING

Bodies modeled in both motifs, rendered into molds, and cast in aluminum on steel bases, every casting hand finished to take paint. Then the studio itself changed: we reconfigured the whole shop and opened a new section so the artists could work on site, and spent most of those months getting them information, materials, and room. Where we had concerns about an artist's materials we raised them through Cortney Lederer of CNL Projects, curator and liaison. Mostly the choice was deliberate, and the artist was right.

IN PLACE

Most pieces held up and surprised us. A few showed nature overtaking a medium, where an artist had stepped away from what we recommended. In Lederer's words: "Twenty-nine artists participated and all required different logistical needs and material expertise, and ChiLab delivered."

DETAILS

Year

2024

Location

Chicago, IL

Category

Public Art

Materials

Cast aluminum, steel, artist applied finishes

CREDITS

Peggy Notebaert Nature Museum

29 Chicago artists

STUDIO

ChiLab Studio

Chicago, Illinois

Established 2013



01 FLIGHT OF BUTTERFLIES



02 FLIGHT OF BUTTERFLIES



03 FLIGHT OF BUTTERFLIES



04 FLIGHT OF BUTTERFLIES



05 FLIGHT OF BUTTERFLIES



06 FLIGHT OF BUTTERFLIES



Bring us a drawing, a model, or a hunch.

THE STUDIO

Specialty material projects for architecture, interior design, public art, and the fine arts.

ChiLab Studio, Chicago, Illinois. Established 2013.

WHAT WE DO

Metal casting

Glass

Finishes

Digital fabrication

Metal fabrication

Restoration

Project management

CONTACT

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